

reply might prove extremely valuable as you decide whether to continue the purchase process.

WHAT'S NOT INCLUDED

The typical inspection will cover most aspects of your potential new home, but in most cases the inspector won't cover a few specialties—though some inspection companies will bundle these if you pay extra on top of your regular inspection. Whether you need to do any extra tests depends on the home, its age, and its location.

One to keep an eye on is the home's source of water. In desert areas, every home sold is required to include a Source of Water Addendum, which tells the buyer where their water comes from—usually from a well or the city. However, not all states have this requirement. If your state does not, you want to be sure you know where the water is coming from. If the source is a well, it's a great idea to have that well inspected.

Also, there are two ways to remove waste from a home: a hookup to a septic system or a hookup to the city sewer. (Or, as Mindy once had in a house she owned, a system that dumped directly into the crawl space beneath the home. Story for another time, maybe?)

Septic systems are more common in rural areas where access to city sewer and water isn't readily available. They need maintenance and care, and if you're considering purchasing a property with a septic system, we strongly encourage you to get a complete system inspection unless the sellers have done so within the last six to twelve months. While a complete inspection can be pricey, a new septic system can run into tens of thousands of dollars. Plus, some can't even be replaced—and a septic system is definitely not something you want to go without.

City sewer, however, is much more common, and it's serviced by the city in which the property is located. In most states, the homeowner is responsible for the sewer pipe that leads from the house to the main sewer line, which is typically (but not always) in the middle of the street. After that, any issues fall to the city.

For example, some older homes were built with clay pipes that can get crushed or shift and are easily infiltrated by tree roots. If you're held